



2025/2026 VICE-CHANCELLOR'S RESEARCH, INNOVATION AND COMMERCIALIZATION GRANT: CALL FOR CONCEPT NOTES

In line with Daystar University's strategic commitment to advancing research, innovation, commercialization, and entrepreneurship, the University is pleased to announce the **2025/2026 Vice-Chancellor's Research, Innovation and Commercialization Grant**.

This grant call is intended to strengthen Daystar University's mandate in research, innovation, product development, and societal impact by supporting high-potential innovations with strong commercialization prospects. The **2025/2026 grant cycle** will particularly focus on **product development, market validation, and commercialization**. The University anticipates supporting **upto 10 successful applicants**.

The Call

The **Directorate of Research, Innovation, Commercialization and Entrepreneurship (DRICE)** invites **innovators, startups, researchers, faculty, staff, students, and university-linked enterprises** to submit **concept notes** for funding support aimed at advancing innovative ideas, products, and technologies from proof-of-concept to market-ready products or services.

This programme is designed to bridge the critical gap between innovation development and commercialization by supporting **product validation, pilot testing, regulatory readiness, market entry, and scale-up efforts**.

Daystar University particularly encourages **faculty student collaboration** in order to promote **mentorship, interdisciplinary engagement, and joint innovation**.

In addition, submissions should, where possible, be linked to **at least one research paper** that is **submitted, in pipeline, or near submission**, in order to strengthen the research and evidence base underpinning the proposed innovation.

Objectives

The objectives of this call are to:

- Support the transition of high-potential innovations and products developed by **Daystar University staff and students** into commercially viable solutions.
- Encourage strategic partnerships between **Daystar University, industry, and other relevant stakeholders**.
- Promote **faculty student collaboration** in research, mentorship, and innovation development.
- Foster innovation, entrepreneurship, and economic impact within and beyond the University.
- Strengthen the University's research-to-commercialization pipeline in alignment with its strategic priorities.

Eligibility Criteria

Applicants must:

- Be a **full-time employee of Daystar University** (teaching or non-teaching), or a **registered Daystar University student** (Certificate, Diploma, Undergraduate, Postgraduate Diploma, Master's, or Doctoral level), or an **incubatee/innovation team formally affiliated with Daystar University**.
- Have a **working Minimum Viable Product (MVP)** or a clearly advanced innovation with commercialization potential.
- Demonstrate linkage, where applicable, to **at least one research paper** that is **submitted, under development, or near submission**.

- Be willing, where applicable, to enter into a **negotiated equity arrangement** with the University.
- Be willing, where applicable, to accept **joint Intellectual Property (IP) registration** with Daystar University in accordance with University policy.
- Be willing to adhere to **Daystar University policies, guidelines, and regulations** governing research, innovation, commercialization, IP, and project management.

Eligible Activities

Funding may be used for:

- Product refinement, prototyping, testing, and launch preparation.
- Regulatory approval, certification, and compliance processes where necessary.
- Pilot deployment and customer or user trials in line with Daystar University commercialization frameworks.
- Intellectual property protection and related legal support for successful applicants.
- Market entry planning, commercialization strategy, and early scale-up activities.

Evaluation Criteria

Submissions will be assessed based on:

- **Commercialization potential**
- **Strength of research evidence**
- **Overall innovation quality**

How to Apply

Applicants should submit their **concept notes** using the prescribed **application form** via email to **drice@daystar.ac.ke**, copied to cvihenda@daystar.ac.ke and jmursi@daystar.ac.ke on or before **20th May 2026 at 5:00 p.m. EAT**.

Shortlisted applicants will be invited to **pitch before a selection panel**.

Important Information to Applicants

- Any application that does not adhere to the prescribed **guidelines on word count, formatting, structure, and eligibility criteria** will not be evaluated.
- Any application received **after the stated deadline** will not be considered.
- **Multiple or duplicate applications** will not be evaluated.
- Only applicants who are **successful after the pitching stage** will be contacted.
Please click here to access the Application Form.